



◀ WAR AND WARRIORS

Unlike the Romans and Greeks, who had disciplined armies, Celts fought as individuals to win glory. Some Celts even fought naked. Leading warriors had helmets with tall crests, topped with birds of prey or boars and worn for display rather than for protection. This Celtic helmet is from a tomb in Romania.

The movable wings actually flapped during battle.

Celtic Europe

From the 6th century BCE, the Iron Age civilization of the Celts stretched across much of Europe. The Celts, who originated from north of the Alps, lived in many large tribes and never saw themselves as a single people. They were fierce warriors and skilled metalworkers.

The Celts spoke a group of related languages, connected to modern Irish and Welsh, and shared customs, religious beliefs, and styles of art. The name “Celt” comes from *Keltoi*—the Greek name for a particular tribe living in France. The Romans called them “Galli” (Gauls), which led to the lands they settled being called Gaul (France), Galicia (in Spain), and Galatia (in Turkey).

Much of what we know of the Celts comes from the writings of the Romans, who eventually conquered most of their lands. The Romans were startled by the independence of Celtic women, who could rule as queens and go into battle. They were also shocked by some of the Celtic religious practices, which included human sacrifice. In Britain and Gaul, this was carried out by priests called druids.

SPREAD OF THE CELTS

800–500 BCE

The first recorded Celtic culture emerges in modern-day Austria. People of the Hallstatt culture bury their dead with bronze ornaments decorated with geometric patterns.

BRONZE BROOCH
FROM HALLSTATT

